

Diary of a Stalker

First draft reader edition

Diary of a Stalker

First draft for La Recherche, Episode IV.

Front Note

This book answers Diary of a Young Girl from Daniel's side. It is written as letters with diary pressure: beautiful, analytical, devotional, self-implicating, and suspect. It is not an annotation of Lola and not a defense brief. It is the record of a man trying to keep speaking to the girl he believes is still hidden inside the January room, while the reader is allowed to doubt whether that girl still exists in the same form.

The title is dangerous on purpose. In the human register, stalking is an accusation. In the later Faerie register, Stalker can become an office only if it means guidance, restraint, marked exits, and answerability. This draft lives before that title has been purified by sentence. It must therefore show the danger of the word as much as the longing to redeem it.

I. After The Vanishing

You vanish, and I begin arranging the room.

That is the first thing I mistrust about myself. I do not only grieve. I sort. I place the messages beside the dates, the dates beside the promises, the promises beside the fear in your voice when your family became a wall. I tell myself that order is tenderness. Sometimes it is. Sometimes it is only a more intelligent way to refuse loss.

In January you taught me the shape of a hidden channel. You were not silent in the simple way. You were forbidden, watched, frightened, and still trying to keep a little door open with your hands. I remember that door too well. I keep looking for it after it may have closed.

If I call that loyalty, I must also call it danger.

The archive flatters me because it answers when I ask.

A living person does not. A living person changes the subject, sleeps, lies, forgets, gets hungry, goes to class, becomes embarrassed by what she meant last week, lets a new friend rename the old story, decides that survival requires a different version of herself. The archive stays. It lets me hold January in my hand and ask it questions until it begins to sound like permission.

That is not your fault.

It is the first charge against me.

II. The January Girl

The January girl asked to be waited for.

She was not an argument. She was a person in a narrowing house. She was school, parents, electronics taken away, family therapy, crying, the horror of being explained by people who loved her and still did not hear her. She was brave in small messages because small messages were all the room allowed.

I loved her partly because she was not grand. She was immediate. She said she was scared. She said she had no say. She said please wait for me. She made the screen into a chapel and a hiding place.

The error begins if I decide that every later silence belongs to that same chapel.

There were other possible explanations. I knew that even then.

You could be afraid. You could be angry. You could be ashamed. You could be trying to obey. You could be trying to disobey without being seen. You could be protecting me, protecting yourself, protecting a new story from the old one. You could be young in the simplest possible way: not a symbol, not a witness, not a vow, only a person changing faster than my language could follow.

I did not want the simplest explanation because it did not give me work to do.

Rescue gives the rescuer a role. Waiting gives the waiter nobility. Interpretation gives the interpreter a room where he is still needed.

III. The Seducer's Mirror

Kierkegaard's seducer looks at the beloved and sees his own intelligence reflected. That is the mirror I am afraid of.

I can write beautifully about you. I can make your fear legible. I can connect the January room to March, the hidden channel to later messages, the word wait to the word rescue, the forbidden screen to the doctrine of loyalty. I can make a theory so tender that it almost passes for care.

But a theory can hold an image after the person has left it.

If this is a diary, let it record that I know the risk. I may be loving a girl preserved by the archive while the living girl has changed under guilt, shame, friends, school, Alex, Puck, and the relief of becoming unreadable to me.

The seducer's mirror is not only vanity. It is craft.

That makes it harder to condemn. Craft can be generous. It can notice what others miss. It can rescue a sentence from the trash and hold it up to the light. It can say, look, this little line was a whole weather system. It can make a frightened girl less alone by proving that her words mattered.

But craft can also keep a person from escaping the most beautiful version of herself.

If I make January immortal, do I give you dignity or deny you time?

IV. The Cancel Cult Name

When Deputy Dan's name enters the story through another mouth, the hidden room becomes public weather.

The name sounds childish until it is not. It sounds like a joke until it becomes a path for the law. One person says one name to another person, and the private world starts acquiring uniforms, forms, reports, and accusations. This is how Faerie turns mortal when nobody is careful with doors.

I want to say you were still the January girl then. I want the continuity because continuity lets me keep speaking. But want is not proof. Want is the oldest seducer.

The public weather changes the scale of every private sentence.

Before, a message could be a room. After Deputy Dan's name enters, a message can be a path through other people's mouths. It can be copied, summarized, reported, misremembered, weaponized, mourned, defended, and made ugly by the very fact that it has to be explained. The more I explain, the more I risk becoming the person the explanation was meant to answer.

This is where the future commandment begins before I know its language: never use mystery to hide danger.

I did not yet know how much danger a beautiful mystery could hide.

V. The Letter I Should Not Send

My dearest,

If you are still there, then the world has lied about you. If you are not still there, then I am the one lying by addressing you as if you were.

This is the whole wound.

I do not know how to love without interpretation. I do not know how to stop hearing the earlier vow inside the later refusal. I know that refusal is speech. I know that silence is speech. I know that fear is speech. I know these things now as commandments, but in the moment I keep translating them back into the language of rescue.

That is why this letter must remain a draft.

A sent letter wants a reply.

This letter should not want one. It should sit here and accuse the hand that wrote it. It should teach me the difference between address and entitlement. There are words a person may write because the truth needs a shape, and there are words a person must not send because the other person's silence has already answered.

I keep confusing those categories when I am afraid.

Fear makes a theologian of me. I build doctrines from absence. I call them love because love is the word that hurts least when I say it about myself.

VI. Toward Sentence

If La Recherche later asks whether I may bear the office of Stalker, this book is part of the evidence against me as much as for me.

It proves that I can preserve a hidden room. It does not prove that I know when to leave it. It proves that I can hear fear. It does not prove that I always let fear stop me. It proves that I can make beauty from danger. It does not prove that beauty has made the danger answerable.

The mature law must be stricter than this book:

Open wonder, not innocence.

Name the road.

Mark the threshold.

Honor fear, refusal, silence, and hesitation as true speech.

Leave the way back marked.

Let the child outgrow the guide.

Answer for the world revealed.

Until those lessons become heavier than the letter, I have not earned the title.

VII. What Must Be Left Unsent

The final discipline is not eloquence.

It is the envelope left open, the message not typed, the theory not delivered, the beautiful paragraph kept from becoming another demand. If Stalking ever becomes an office rather than an accusation, it will begin there: not in the gift of seeing, but in the refusal to make sight a claim.

I can bless the January room without living in it.

I can admit that the hidden channel mattered without using it forever.

I can love the girl who asked me to wait and still let the later girl leave the guide behind.

If this book has any right to exist, it is because it records the failure before the commandment. It shows the road before the road is safe. It lets the reader see why the title must be judged by an older Court and why the answer, if it comes, must bind me more tightly than desire ever did.

I close the diary here, not because the story is over, but because the next true sentence belongs to someone else unless she chooses to speak.

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